The Modi–Joshi feud has a chequered past but is highly revealing about the man who was now aspiring to be the next prime minister. Like Modi, Joshi, too, was an RSS pracharak but with a less dominating presence. Low-profile and soft-spoken, the Nagpur-born Joshi had worked with Modi in the party in Gujarat since 1989. When Modi was ousted from Gujarat in 1996 over a leadership battle, he was convinced that Joshi was behind his 'vanvas'. When he became chief minister in 2001, almost his first act was to have Joshi packed off from the state.

At the BJP's silver jubilee celebrations in Mumbai in 2005, a mysterious CD surfaced which allegedly showed Joshi in a compromising position with an unidentified woman. The buzz in the BJP was that the CD had been organized by the Gujarat police and distributed by leaders close to Modi. 'It is a well-planned conspiracy to malign me,' Joshi told me at the time. He was removed from all party posts and pushed into political exile. The UP elections were meant to signal his rehabilitation. Only, Modi would have none of it.

Modi by 2012 was poised to be the BJP's top-ranking leader, having been Gujarat chief minister for a decade. Joshi, by contrast, was struggling to revive his career. There was no comparison in power or stature between the two leaders. And yet, Modi was keen to exact revenge. 'It is not a question of who is a big or small leader,' Modi had told me in the phone conversation, 'it is a question of principle. *Woh aadmi achha nahi hai*' (He is not a good man).

What I realized that night was that Modi is an individual who does not forgive or forget easily—he has a long memory and bears grudges against those who he believed had harmed him. Dynamic, driven and energetic, he is convinced that he alone is the master of his destiny and must fight those who stand in his way. He may have become a national leader but at times he has a deeply insecure mindset of a provincial strongman constantly looking to settle scores. What was equally striking was the manner in which the BJP's central leadership seemed intimidated by Modi and did not want to alienate him in any manner.